



DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC SAFETY GEORGIA STATE PATROL

PURSUIT CRITIQUE

TROOPER NAME – TFC Cody Cantrell #136 and TFC William Mefford #601

Work Assignment: Troop/Division - A; Post/Unit – 43 - Calhoun

INCIDENT REPORT # DPS00163805

Related Crash Reports: C000957910 ; C000957911 ; C000957912; C000957913

P.I.T. Involved: Yes

S.C.R.T. Involved: No

Special Investigations Unit Involved: No

Use of Force Involved: Yes

MEETING

1. Document the date, time and location of the pursuit critique meeting with the involved trooper.

Date: 6/29/2024

Time: 1525 Hours

Location: Post 43 - Calhoun

2. List all personnel present at the meeting by name and rank. Include the trooper, an NCO in whose territory the pursuit was terminated, and the trooper's immediate supervisor.

Personnel present: Lieutenant Tim Nichols #36, SFC Tony Rathel #408, TFC Cody Cantrell #136, TFC William Mefford #601 and Cadet Johnathan Tate #631

INITIATION

1. Provide the date and time the trooper became involved in the pursuit.

Date: 6/19/2024

Time: 1630 Hours

2. Explain the circumstances that led to the trooper's involvement in the pursuit.

On 6/19/2024, agents with the Murray County Drug Task Force contacted TFC Mefford and requested the assistance of the Georgia State Patrol in stopping a vehicle driven by a suspected drug supplier out of Chattanooga, Tennessee. The agents provided a description of the vehicle but didn't know the supplier's name. At approximately 1630 hours, TFC Cantrell met the suspected vehicle traveling southbound on GA 225 in Murray County. When TFC Cantrell attempted to stop the vehicle, the violator fled and a pursuit ensued.

3. If trooper's involvement was the result of a request from another agency, provide details regarding the request.

☐ N/A If Yes, explain: Agents from the Murray County Drug Task Force requested GSP assistance in stopping a black Hyundai Sonata that was being driven by a suspected drug supplier out of Chattanooga, Tennessee. The drug agents didn't know the supplier's name, they only had his description along with information that he might also be armed.

4. List the number and identity of other agencies and officers involved in the pursuit.

☒ N/A If needed, list:

5. If other occupants were in the patrol vehicle, identify them and state their reason for being in the vehicle.

☐ N/A If Yes, list: Cadet Tate was riding with TFC Cantrell and Dispatcher Brady McWhorter was on an approved ride-along with TFC Mefford.

6. Did the trooper take appropriate safety precautions?

☒ Yes ☐ No If no, explain:

7. Did the trooper eliminate distractions such as FM radio noise?

☒ Yes ☐ No If no, explain:

COMMUNICATION

1. If the reporting trooper initiated the pursuit by means of observing a violation and attempting a traffic stop, explain the communication that took place between the trooper and the CEO.

☐ N/A If Yes, explain: TFC Cantrell contacted the Troop A Communications Center by radio and advised them that he was in a pursuit. TFC Cantrell provided his location, directions of travel and description of the vehicle. Dispatcher Hopson received this information and created a CAD call for the pursuit.

2. Did the trooper relay pertinent information to the CEO including:

- Location and direction of travel.
- Description of the pursued vehicle.
- Number and description of occupants.
- Information regarding the use of firearms, threat of force, or other hazard.
- Options for terminating the pursuit.
- Observed danger to public safety.
- Any need for assistance.

☒ Yes ☐ No If no, explain:

3. Explain any communication that took place between the CEO and other law enforcement agencies or officers in the area.

☐ N/A Explain: Once the pursuit initiated, Dispatcher Hopson cleared the radio for emergency traffic before conducting a broadcast of the pursuit to all Troop A Troopers. Dispatcher Raymond contacted the Murray County 911 Center while Senior Dispatcher Loyd contacted the Gordon County 911 Center by telephone to advise them of the pursuit and requested assistance.

4. If the reporting trooper became involved in the pursuit at the request of another agency, explain any communication that took place between the trooper and another officer of the requesting agency. Give details of communication between the CEO and the requesting agency regarding the location, direction of travel, nature of the offense, any pending warrants, and details of erratic driving behavior illustrating the potential danger to the public if the suspect is not immediately apprehended.

☐ N/A If Yes, explain: Agents from the Murray County Drug Task Force requested GSP assistance in stopping a black Hyundai Sonata that was being driven by a suspected drug supplier out of Chattanooga, Tennessee. The drug agents didn't know the supplier's name, they only had his description along with information that he might also be armed.

5. Did the trooper articulate his observations?

☒ Yes ☐ No If no, explain:

6. At the conclusion of the pursuit, did the trooper advise the CEO immediately, so other units would be familiar with the location to offer assistance, or slow in an effort to reduce the likelihood of further risk of injury to either a trooper or a member of the general public?

☒ Yes ☐ No If no, explain:

7. Discuss any needed areas of improvement with the CEO.

☒ N/A If Yes, explain:

PURSUIT

1. Describe the route the pursuit traveled, its duration and distance.

Describe: The pursuit initiated on GA 225 South near Brown Bridge Road and traveled southbound approximately 14.3 miles. The pursuit terminated in Gordon County on GA 225 at I-75. The pursuit lasted 9 minutes and 24 seconds.

2. Were the trooper's actions during the pursuit objectively reasonable?

☒ Yes ☐ No If no, explain:

3. If the pursuit traveled into another post's territory, explain whether the initiating trooper yielded to a trooper whose territory the pursuit was in.

☒ N/A If Yes, explain:

4. If the initiating trooper yielded the primary position to another unit, explain whether he proceeded to the termination point of the pursuit to provide guidance and information for the arrest of the violator.

☐ N/A If Yes, explain: Near Spring Place Reseca Road, TFC Mefford momentarily took the primary position in the pursuit. Approximately two miles later, TFC Cantrell took over the primary position again just south of GA 136.

5. Explain if there were any factors during the pursuit that indicated the possible commission of a felony.

☐ N/A If Yes, explain: The violator's actions during the pursuit support a charge of Felony Fleeing and Attempting to Elude.

6. Did the trooper articulate his observations?

☒ Yes ☐ No If no, explain:

7. Did the trooper practice commentator driving?

☒ Yes ☐ No If no, explain:

8. Did the trooper remain calm and professional during the pursuit?

☒ Yes ☐ No If no, explain:

DRIVING SKILLS

1. Did the trooper use due caution when operating his vehicle during the pursuit?

☒ Yes ☐ No If no, explain:

2. Were the driving skills/techniques initiated appropriately?

☒ Yes ☐ No If no, explain:

3. Were the driving skills/techniques appropriate during the pursuit?

☒ Yes ☐ No If no, explain:

4. Were the driving skills/techniques appropriate during termination?

☒ Yes ☐ No If no, explain:

5. Did the trooper appear to experience adrenalin rush, tunnel vision, or any other internal/external factors?

☒ No If Yes, explain:

6. Did the trooper get into the danger zone due to adrenalin rush, tunnel vision, or other factors?

☒ No If Yes, explain:

EQUIPMENT

1. Were the blue lights and siren in operation during the entire pursuit?

☒ Yes ☐ No If no, explain:

2. If the patrol car was equipped with wig-wag headlights, were they in operation during the entire pursuit?

☒ Yes ☐ No If no, explain:

3. Was the in-car camera working properly?

☒ Yes ☐ No If no, explain:

4. Was the trooper's microphone working properly?

☒ Yes ☐ No If no, explain:

TERMINATION

1. Did the trooper continue the pursuit to a conclusion? If not, explain the reasons.

☒ Yes ☐ No If no, explain:

2. Was there a good probability of the suspect's arrest at a later time because of positive identification?

☒ N/A If Yes, explain:

3. Articulate attempts taken by the trooper to utilize pursuit termination techniques, such as tire deflating devices, roadblocks, P.I.T. maneuver, and trooper discretion.

☐ N/A Explain: Knowing that there was no one ahead of the pursuit to deploy Stop Sticks, and the Box-In Maneuver wasn't an option due to the violator's reckless actions, TFC Cantrell made the decision to implement a Precision Immobilization Technique Maneuver in order to terminate the pursuit. TFC Cantrell made two attempts by making contact between the left rear of the Hyundai and the right front of TFC Cantrell's patrol vehicle. However, during both attempts, TFC Cantrell failed to get high enough up on the left side while making contact with the Hyundai. As a result, both attempts were unsuccessful. As the pursuit approached the northbound entrance ramp to I-75, TFC Cantrell attempted another PIT by making contact between the right rear of the Hyundai and the left front of TFC Cantrell's patrol vehicle. AS TFC Cantrell was steering into the vehicle, the violator counter steered and was able to drive out of the PIT. TFC Cantrell then set up on the left side of the Hyundai again and made contact with the left rear and the right front of his patrol car. As the Hyundai began to rotate counterclockwise, TFC Cantrell began to push the vehicle across the center of the roadway and into the northbound lane of GA 225 before coming to a stop.

4. Expound on safety precautions utilized by the trooper during and after the pursuit.

☐ N/A Explain: TFC Cantrell and TFC Mefford utilized all their emergency equipment throughout the pursuit and operated their vehicles in a responsible manner. Cadet Tate called the pursuit which allowed TFC Cantrell to concentrate on his driving skills. While TFC Mefford was in the primary position, Cadet Tate continued to call the pursuit in order for TFC Mefford to concentrate on his driving. At the end of the pursuit, TFC Cantrell, TFC Mefford and Cadet Tate didn't take any unnecessary risks and used good officer safety techniques while taking the violator and occupants into custody.

5. Articulate the existing traffic conditions during the pursuit, realizing the conditions may differ at various times during the pursuit.

Explain: The pursuit occurred during daytime hours with clear skies and a dry road surface. The traffic on GA 225 at the time of the pursuit would be described as moderate.

6. Address whether there are any conditions that would create additional danger to the public by continuing the pursuit.

☐ N/A If Yes, explain: The suspect demonstrated no intentions of stopping for law enforcement. The suspect traveled at very high speeds and failed to stop for a stop sign during the pursuit to avoid apprehension. The suspect drove on the wrong side of the road for extended periods and improperly passed other motorists. The suspect's actions put the public's safety and all involved in jeopardy.

7. Address whether there were any conditions that necessitated the pursuit being brought to an immediate conclusion and describe the conditions.

☐ N/A If Yes, explain: The suspect demonstrated no intentions of stopping for law enforcement. The suspect traveled at very high speeds during the pursuit to avoid apprehension, drove on the wrong side of the road and improperly passed other motorists. The suspect's actions put the public's safety and all involved in jeopardy. These facts necessitated the pursuit be brought to a conclusion in order to safeguard the public from harm.

8. Establish whether the violator was an immediate threat to the trooper, the public or themselves.

☐ N/A If Yes, explain: The violator fled at speeds in excess of 100 miles per hour, drove on the wrong side of the road and improperly passed other vehicles. The violator showed no regard for the safety of himself, his passenger or law enforcement officers.

9. Outline whether the use of deadly force was justified and if so, why it was justified.

☒ N/A If Yes, explain:

10. Establish whether the method of termination was reasonable based on the facts gathered during the pursuit, and state those facts.

☐ N/A If Yes, explain: TFC Cantrell executed the PIT maneuver in order to terminate the pursuit. There were no units ahead of the pursuit to deploy Stop Sticks, and the Box-In maneuver was not feasible due to the reckless nature of the violator's driving. The recklessness of the violator's driving posed a great risk to himself and others, and it necessitated that the pursuit be terminated as soon as practical. TFC Cantrell's decision to implement the PIT maneuver was objectively reasonable in order to safeguard life and preserve public safety.

11. If there were any injuries, state who received them, the type and severity.

☒ N/A If Yes, explain:

12. If there was a fatality, provide basic facts surrounding the circumstances.

☒ N/A If Yes, explain:

13. Address any damage to vehicles.

☐ N/A If Yes, explain: The Hyundai and TFC Cantrell's patrol vehicle sustained disabling damage as a result of the PIT.

TROOPER'S ABILITIES AND EXPERIENCE

1. Prior pursuits (compare if appropriate).

☐ N/A If Yes, explain: TFC Cantrell and TFC Mefford have been involved in numerous pursuits during their careers as Georgia State Troopers.

2. Past use of techniques and high speed driving.

☐ N/A If Yes, explain: TFC Cantrell and TFC Mefford have received E.V.O.C., Advanced E.V.O.C. and Pursuit-Ending Tactics Training.

ISSUES ADDRESSED

1. Positives.

☐ N/A If Yes, explain: TFC Cantrell exercised good decision making skills when he chose to implement the PIT maneuvers. There was good commentating and communications throughout the pursuit.

2. Areas for improvement.

☐ N/A If Yes, explain: During the final PIT attempt, as TFC Cantrell pushed the Hyundai into the northbound lane of GA 225, he pushed the vehicle into the path of a northbound motorcyclist who was able to stop before a collision occurred. TFC Cantrell was instructed to always look for oncoming traffic before implementing a PIT.

3. Other considerations.

☐ N/A If Yes, explain: At the conclusion of the pursuit, TFC Cantrell, TFC Mefford and Cadet Tate drew and pointed their service weapons while taking the violator into custody. A Use of Force Report was completed.

RESPONSE FROM TROOPER OR SUPERVISOR

1. Allow trooper and supervisor an opportunity to respond or add comments.

☒ N/A If Yes, explain:

CORRECTIVE ACTION TAKEN

1. Describe any corrective action taken as a result of the trooper's actions during the pursuit.

☒ N/A If Yes, explain:

Lt. T. L. Nichols #36 *Lt. T. L. Nichols #36*
Reviewing Officer

7/2/2024
Date